Sheringham made it 2–1 and then, in injury time at the end, we were awarded a free-kick just outside the Leicester penalty area. I stepped up and there was this hush around the ground: it was eerie, the silence. Anybody who was there, I'm sure, will remember it. The only voice I could hear was the one in my head. *Please go in. Please, please go in.*

Once I'd struck it with the inside of my right foot, the ball spun up over the wall and down into the corner of the goal, almost in slow motion, it seemed. The time it took for the shot to go past the goalkeeper was enough for me to realize what a perfect moment this was. I ran to the corner flag with my arms stretched out and spun round in a sort of clumsy pirouette. I knew exactly what I wanted to say to the United supporters above the roar. *I didn't know what to expect. Thank you for standing by me. That goal's for you*.

I've always felt in control when I was out on the field. However difficult it was with away crowds, I could get on with playing. If I was kicking a ball, there was never a chance of anything else distracting me. Away from soccer, though, it got stranger and stranger. Victoria was on tour most of the time and Mum and Dad had gone back to London to work. I was on my own in the evenings at home. I remember one night in particular. The house in Worsley had an alarm system, so I wasn't worried about anybody breaking in. But, that night, a bang—sounding like it was coming from out in the garden—woke me up. I got a sinking feeling in the pit of my stomach, not knowing what was going on but fearing the worst. The police had given me an emergency number to ring in case anything happened but I decided to check for myself. I didn't want to call them out if it was just a cat trying to get into my garbage bin.

I got out of bed and crept down the stairs. I leaned down and looked out of the landing window. Standing at the back fence was this bloke, arms crossed, looking back up at me. First thing I remembered was that I didn't have any clothes on. He just stared at me. It was like some weird kind of hypnotism. He wasn't moving and I couldn't either. Eventually, I pulled the window open and shouted at him.

'What do you want?'

He didn't move a muscle. He didn't reply. He just stood there, staring up at me, not caring at all that I'd seen him. I think those moments were the scariest of the lot. I don't know how long the pair of us were there, looking at one another. I didn't know what was going on, never mind knowing what I could do about it. I rang the police but, by the time they arrived, the man had